

ECON 100-01: Introduction to Microeconomics

Fall 2025
Allegheny College
The Business and Economics Department

Class Time: M/W/F, 09:00am-09:50am

Classroom: Quigley Hall 215

Instructor: Hang Zhao

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Office hours: M/F 10:00am-12:00pm. **Location:** Quigley Hall 208

Tu/W 7:00pm-8:00pm. **Location:** Virtual

Office Hours Booking: <https://calendar.app.google/PD6Ku9PSCZ716K5D7>

Course Description: This course introduces the fundamental principles of microeconomics, with an emphasis on how individuals, firms, and governments make decisions under conditions of scarcity. Topics include incentives, supply and demand, the efficiency of markets, and the role of government in market outcomes. Students will explore core concepts such as consumer and producer behavior, market efficiency, the economics of taxation and international trade, and the role of externalities and public goods. Through lectures, discussions, and problem-solving exercises, the course develops both intuitive and analytical skills for understanding market behavior and outcomes.

Distribution Requirements:

The following definitions were taken from the Distribution Requirements: Learning Outcomes website, <https://sites.allegheny.edu/registrar/academic-policies/graduation-requirements/distribution-requirement/distribution-requirements-learning-outcomes/>.

- **Quantitative Reasoning (QR).** Quantitative Reasoning is the ability to understand, investigate, communicate, and contextualize numerical, symbolic, and graphical information towards the exploration of natural, physical, behavioral, or social phenomena.
 - **Learning Outcome:** Students who successfully complete this requirement will demonstrate an understanding of how to interpret numeric data and/or their graphical or symbolic representations.
- **Social Behavior and Institutions (SB).** The study of Social Behavior and Institutions encompasses a broad range of disciplines that use a variety of methodologies to describe, explain, or predict human behavior, social processes, and institutional structures as they interact with their environments
 - **Learning Outcome:** Students who successfully complete this requirement will demonstrate an understanding of at least one methodology used to describe, explain, or predict human behavior at the level of the individual, small group, institution, organization, community, or population.

Course Learning Outcomes:

This course is specially tailored to build up your understanding and enhance your abilities in the exciting field of microeconomics. As we explore the course content together, you will be guided towards achieving the following learning outcomes:

1. Explore how the market economy drives the production, distribution, and consumption of goods and services.

2. Explain with math, graphs, and the written word the logic and insights of standard microeconomic models.
3. Employ the fundamentals of economic thinking to evaluate personal, business, and public policy decision making.

Learning Resources (optional):

- Mankiw, N. G. (2024). Principles of Microeconomics (10th ed.).

There is no required textbook for the course. Older editions of Mankiw's "Principles of Microeconomics" will suffice as a supplement in addition to the course materials. Expect to engage with news articles, videos, podcast and other resources that complement your learning, giving you a fuller picture of how the economy works. These resources will be uploaded to Canvas.

- Tutoring: <https://sites.allegheeny.edu/studentsuccess/tutoring/tutor-request/>

Grading:

- Class Attendance (5%)
- Class Participation (5%)
- Reflection Journal (5%)
- Presentation (5%)
- Homework Assignments (15%)
- Quizzes (15%)
- Mid-term Exam (25%)
- Final Exam (25%)

Grading Components

- ***Class Attendance.*** Attendance is required. You may have up to **two unexcused absences** without penalty. After that, each additional unexcused absence will reduce your attendance grade:
 0–2 absences: Full credit (5/5)
 3 absences: 4/5
 4 absences: 3/5
 5 absences: 2/5
 6 or more absences: 0-1/5, and successful completion of the course may be at risk
 If you must miss class due to illness or emergency, please email me as soon as possible so we can determine whether it can be considered excused.
- ***Class Participation.*** Participation means more than just being present. It includes being prepared, attentive, and actively engaging in class. This may involve asking or answering questions, contributing to discussions, taking part in group activities, and demonstrating respect toward classmates and the instructor.

Participation Rubric:

Level	Description	Grade Range
Excellent	Always prepared; engages thoughtfully in nearly every class; consistently contributes meaningful questions, answers, or insights; respectful to peers.	90–100%
Good	Prepared and engaged in most classes; contributes regularly, though not always deeply; respectful in class.	80–90%
Fair	Sometimes prepared; minimal or inconsistent participation; contributes occasionally without much depth.	60–70%
Poor	Rarely prepared; seldom participates; often distracted or disengaged; may disrupt class.	≤ 60%

- **Reflection Journal.** A key component of this course is the Reflection Journal, which should be **2–4 pages long** and maintained throughout the semester. It should be double-spaced, use approximately **1-inch margins**, and be written in **10- or 12-point font**. This journal serves as your personal space to reflect on course content, class discussions, and your own learning journey. Your entries may include:

- Insights from lectures or in-class activities
- Personal thoughts on how economic principles apply to real-world scenarios
- Articles or news stories that relate to course topics

For example, you are encouraged to identify and reflect on current events or articles that align with the economic concepts covered in class. You need to submit a short proposal that includes:

- Your chosen topic
- Your motivation for selecting this topic
- A brief explanation of how the topic relates to our course content

Your completed journal paper will be graded according to the following criteria:

Topic selection	1
Motivation	1
Relates to class	1
Application to world/Real Life	2
Total Points	5

- **Presentation.** Each student will deliver a presentation of at least 5 minutes on a topic related to the course content. This exercise aims to develop your ability to communicate complex economic concepts clearly and effectively. Presentations will be assessed on content accuracy, clarity of explanation, and engagement with the audience. You will receive more details on the expectations and guidelines for presentations, including topics and scheduling, in our upcoming classes.
- **Homework Assignments.** There will be 3 assignments to prepare you for the quizzes and exams. Questions will include multiple-choice and open-ended questions, similar to both exams. You will need to complete three assignments well (i.e., answer all questions correctly) to get a maximum score of 15. Detailed instructions and due dates for each assignment will be provided on Canvas.

- Assignments must be submitted by the due date prior to class. Note: In general, late submissions will not be accepted for a grade. Those students with excused absences are expected to turn in assignments on or before the due date. Feel free to collaborate in discussing approaches and answers to the problems in small groups. However, each student should turn in a separate, individually prepared set of answers.
- **Quizzes.** You will be required to complete three quizzes. These are designed to assess your understanding of the material covered in lectures, as well as your engagement with all course materials. Not only will they test your comprehension, but they will also serve as valuable preparation for the midterm and final exams, reinforcing the key concepts you need to master. It's important to stay up to date with the course content to perform well in these quizzes.
- **Exams.** There will be one mid-term and one final exam. Exams will be administered in person. All work submitted for exams must be yours alone. The midterm will be on material covered before the exam, while the final exam will be cumulative. **If you miss an exam, you will get a zero.** If you have a legitimate reason to miss an exam, I need to be contacted by the Office of Student Affairs before issuing you a makeup exam. It will not be possible to reschedule the exams at short notice to accommodate athletic events, job interviews, or conference visits. Also, do not book your flight before you know the exam date! Discussing exam questions with anyone during the exam period violates academic integrity expectations for this course.

Email Communication Guideline:

Please format the subject line of all emails regarding this course with the following structure: 'ECON 100 - [Section Number]: [Brief Description of Topic]'. For example, if you have a question about the upcoming exam, your subject line should read 'ECON 100-02: Exam Question'. This helps to ensure that your email is promptly noticed and sorted into the correct category for a faster response.

Tentative Schedule:

Weeks	Topics
Week 1	Ten Principles of Economics (First Day of Class: Tue, Aug 26)
Week 2	Thinking Like an Economist (No Class: M, Sep 1 – Labor Day)
Week 3	Gains from Trade
Week 4	Supply and Demand – Part 1 (No Class: F, Sep 19 – Blue & Gold Weekend)
Week 5	Supply and Demand – Part 2
Week 6	Elasticity
Week 7	Fall Break – No Classes (Thu–Sun, Oct 9–12)
Week 8	Supply, Demand, and Government Policies
Week 9	Consumers, Producers, and the Efficiency of Markets (No Class: F, Oct 24 – Reading Day)
Week 10	Cost of Taxation
Week 11	International Trade
Week 12	Externalities and Public Goods

Week 13	Cost of Production
Week 14	Thanksgiving Break – No Classes (Wed–Sun, Nov 26–30)
Week 15	Firms in Competitive Markets

Key Dates (Tentative):

Dates	Notes
Sep 12 (Fri)	Quiz 1 – Covers Weeks 1–3 (Ten Principles to Gains from Trade)
Oct 3 (Fri)	Quiz 2 – Covers Weeks 4–6 (Supply & Demand to Elasticity)
Oct 8 (Wed)	Midterm Exam – Covers Weeks 1–7 (before Fall Break)
Oct 24 (Fri)	Reflection Journal Proposal due
Oct 31 (Fri)	Quiz 3 – Covers Weeks 8–10 (Efficiency and Cost of Taxation)
Nov 21 (Fri)	Reflection Journal due
Nov 24 (Mon)	Final Review Session
Dec 1–5	Final Presentations
Dec 8 (Mon)	Final Exam (Code A) – 9:00 am

Policy on the use of Technology and Generative AI:

This course is about building your understanding of economic concepts and strengthening your skills in reading, writing, and critical thinking. To get the most out of class, our shared attention should be on the course material and on each other.

Electronic devices are often a source of distraction, both for the person using them and for others. For that reason, **the use of laptops, tablets, and cell phones in class is not permitted** unless explicitly for class-related purposes and with the instructor's approval. The only electronic devices permitted for regular use are dedicated electronic notebooks (such as Remarkable or similar devices) used solely for note-taking. Use of a cell phone, laptop, or other unauthorized device during class will be marked with an unexcused absence for the day.

Generative AI platforms are now in wide use on college campuses and in the workplace. I encourage you to use these tools responsibly while preparing for class – for example, to review concepts or help explain difficult material.

However, all assignments in this course (homework, reading responses, exams, etc.) must reflect your own original work. Submitting AI-generated work as your own will be treated as academic dishonesty and will be submitted to Allegheny's Honor Committee.

The purpose of this policy is to encourage you to do the kind of thinking and practice that builds long-term skills. By focusing during class and doing your own work, you will leave this course better prepared to think critically, communicate clearly, and apply economic reasoning in future classes and beyond.

I welcome conversations about how you use technology and AI in your learning. If you are unsure whether a certain use is appropriate, please ask, I would be happy to clarify.

Statement of Community

Allegheny students and employees are committed to creating an inclusive, respectful and safe residential learning community that will actively confront and challenge racism, sexism, heterosexism, religious bigotry, and other forms of harassment and discrimination. We encourage individual growth by promoting a free exchange of ideas in a setting that values diversity, trust and equality. So that the right of all to participate in a shared learning experience is upheld, Allegheny affirms its commitment to the

principles of freedom of speech and inquiry, while at the same time fostering responsibility and accountability in the exercise of these freedoms.

Educational Accommodations (prepared by SASS)

Students with disabilities who believe they may need accommodations in this class are encouraged to contact Student Accessibility and Support Services (SASS) at (814) 332-2898. Student Accessibility and Support Services is located in Pelletier Library. Please do this as soon as possible to ensure that such accommodations are implemented in a timely fashion. Please see <https://sites.allegheny.edu/studentaccessibility/> for more details.

Religious Observance (prepared by SRL)

If you need to miss class or reschedule a final examination due to a religious observance, please speak to the professor well in advance to make arrangements. Please see <https://sites.allegheny.edu/religiouslife/religious-holy-days/> for more details.

Academic Integrity

Allegheny College has a student-run Honor Code designed to promote individual responsibility and integrity in academic affairs. Each student pledges the following: “I hereby recognize and pledge to fulfill my responsibilities, as defined in the Honor Code, and to maintain the integrity of both myself and the College community as a whole.” Your professor will educate you about the meaning of academic integrity in this course, which may be different in some respects from other courses in which you are enrolled. Please ask the professor if you have questions. Please see <https://sites.allegheny.edu/studentsuccess/academic-honor-program/> for more details.

Academic Alerts (prepared by MCSS)

Allegheny College uses an Academic Alert system to send progress notices to the class deans in the Maytum Center for Student Success (MCSS). **The progress notices are not punitive.** They are an opportunity to connect you with your class dean who can offer additional support and suggest resources if you need assistance. These notices may encourage faculty advisors, coaches (for student-athletes), or other support staff to provide outreach to you as well.